system, closing understaffed offices and making the remaining offices responsible for more people, and sending more medical students into family doctor residencies.

In an August, 2009 report, Amnesty International documented other obstacles facing Cuba's health system. Key among them was the U.S. embargo. "The restrictions imposed on trade and financing, with their extraterritorial aspects, severely limit Cuba's capacity to import medicines, medical equipment, and the latest technologies, some of which are essential for treating life-threatening diseases and maintaining Cuba's public health programmes," Amnesty concluded.[1]

Also disturbing were the comments of some old friends, a couple in their early sixties. They are professionals, free thinkers shaped by and deeply committed to the Revolution, both working in fields that kept them engaged with constantly rethinking how to bring about social justice and economic development. Their only daughter, also highly educated and motivated, had married since the last time I saw them. She met her husband, a Spaniard, through her work when he was on business in Havana. They, and their new baby, now live in Spain.

"We call ourselves the generation of orphan parents," my friend sighed. "All of our friends are in the same predicament. Their children worked hard, got educated – and now there is no opportunity for them here. What would my daughter's life have been, if she'd stayed? The daily struggle, waiting for us to die so they could have our apartment?"

I do not wish to sum up the Cuban revolutionary experience or cast an overarching judgment on it. The Revolution has been wildly audacious, experimental, and diverse. It has evolved under often adverse circumstances. It created unprecedented socioeconomic equality, and showed the world that it is indeed possible for a poor, Third World country to feed, educate, and provide health care for its population. It fostered astonishing artistic and intellectual creativity, while also creating stifling bureaucracies and limits on freedoms that many in the United States take for granted. It also showed just how extraordinarily difficult it is to overcome economic underdevelopment.

The history of the Cuban Revolution is still unfolding, and the most educated predictions have proven wrong again and again. I left Cuba in